The Invention of Wings

By Sue Monk Kidd

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: Actress 1: Hetty, Mauma, Overseer
Actress 2: Sarah, Mother, Reverend Hall, Father

TOGTHER: *(Both actresses with their bacsk to the audience hum the chorus from "I'll Fly Away"; Sarah continues to hum while Hetty turns and speaks the next line, then Sarah fades away)*

HETTY: **(Pg 3)** Mauma told me one night when I was ten years old [that] there was a time in Africa the people could fly. She said . . .

MAUMA: Handful, your granny-mauma saw it for herself. They flew over trees and clouds. They flew like blackbirds . . . When we came here, we left that magic behind. *(beat)* You don't believe me? Where you think these shoulder blades of yours come from, girl? This all what left of your wings, but one day you gon get 'em back.

HETTY: Even at ten I knew this story about people flying was pure malarkey. We weren't some special people who lost our magic.

SARAH: **(Pg 9)** Our house had fourteen-slaves

HETTY: **(Pg 3)** We were slave people and we weren't going anywhere. It was [only] later I saw what [mauma] meant.

SARAH: **(Pg 8)** I'll never forget my eleventh birthday. Mother had the slaves preparing for my party . . .

MOTHER: **(Pg 14)** [And when the party began] *(claps her hands and brings Hetty to the forefront, Hetty keeps her head down and hands clasped in front of her. Mother*

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straightens a ribbon tied in a bow around Hetty's neck.) This is our little Hetty. Sarah, dear, she is your present, your very own waiting maid. Happy birthday *(she turns Hetty in a circle)*

SARAH: I'm sorry, Mother. . . . . I can't accept . . . I don't need a waiting maid . . . I'm perfectly fine without one.

MOTHER: *Enough!* **(Pg 16)** Your guardianship is legal and binding. Hetty is yours, Sarah, there is nothing to be done about it. This is our way of life . . . make your peace with it.

SARAH: . . . Mother, please, let me. . . let me give Hetty back . . . *Give Hetty back.* As if she was mine after all. As if owning people was as natural as breathing.

HETTY: **(Pg 3)** We could fly all right, but it wasn't any magic to it.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 2: *Sarah Grimke grew up in an aristocratic, slave-holding family surrounded by privilege.*
ACTRESS 1: *But at age 11, when she defies the law and teaches her maid, Hetty, to read and write,*
ACTRESS 2: *Their unequal punishments launch Sarah on a path that would shape her entire future. Sarah Grimké became a committed abolitionist, writer, and suffragist.*
ACTRESS 1: *But she never forgot her roots . . .*
ACTRESS 2: *Never forgot Hetty . . .*
ACTRESS 1: *Never forgot that one time before slavery clipped their wings, the African people could fly.*
TOGETHER: *The Invention of Wings by Sue Monk Kidd*

SARAH: **(Pg 25)** At the age of eleven, I owned a slave I couldn't free.

HETTY: **(Pg 22)** *(knocking at Sarah's door)* Miss Sarah, Miss Sarah, you want me to come in there?

SARAH: *(awkward and sad)* . . . . Yes, come in . . . I'm pleased to have you for my waiting maid.

HETTY: Sure is cold *(rubbing her arms and shivering)*

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SARAH: . . . You could lay a fire, I guess.

HETTY: *(a stricken look on her face, to audience)* I'd seen it done, but seeing ain't doing. *(she begins to work on the fireplace)* I didn't know to check the flue . . . *(panics and begins waving her arms)* and here came all this smoke. *(Sarah begins coughing and waving her arms to clear the smoke . . . she opens a window)* Oh missus, I sorry! *(Sarah takes Hetty's hands; the girls look at one another and dissolve into giggles; Hetty exits)*

SARAH: **(Pg 56)** But we were crossing a dangerous line, Hetty and I. **(Pg 29)** Mother had already taken her cane to Hetty once. *(Sarah exits)*

MOTHER: **(pg 23-24)** Hetty, you incompetent fool! *(brings her cane down on the top of Hetty's head; Hetty drops to her knees; Mother raises her arm for another blow, then freezes in place)*

HETTY: I can't describe what came next. A voice called steady in my head: Get up from there and look her in the face. Dare her to strike you. Dare her. *(Hetty stands up and pokes her face up at Mother; she has anger and contempt in her eyes. Mother lest her arm drop and stepsd back; then exits)* **(Pg 27)** *(to audience)* That first week, beside the smoke, I spilled lamp oil on the floor, broke one of those porcelain vases and fried a piece of Miss Sarah's hair with a curling tong. Miss Sarah never tattled.

SARAH: **(Pg 30)** I never meant to own [Hetty] . . . I tried to free her, but . . . I wasn't allowed. **(Pg 31)** The most I could ever offer her was kindness.

HETTY: **(Pg 89)** We were friends!

TOGETHER: [that's what] I told myself.

SARAH: **(Pg 55)** Side by side, we sang songs, we played. *(girls play a quick game of tag, giggling)*

HETTY: **(Pg 54)** *(to audience)* I didn't know for sure whether Miss Sarah's feelings came from love or guilt. I [just] know she loved me. And I loved her. *(Sarah exits)*

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(Pg 96) [In those days] Missus was dragging us into the dining room for devotions . . .

MOTHER: *(preaching from the Bible)* Be content with your lot, for this is of the Lord.

HETTY: *(to audience)* I wanted to say . . .Take your lot and put it where the sun don't shine! **(Pg 4)** [But] already that morning missus had taken her cane to me for falling asleep during her devotions. If you nodded off, you got whacked right in the middle of God said this and God said that and Jesus wept. Jesus wept cause he was trapped in there with missus like us! *(Hetty exits)*

SARAH: **(Pg 38-39)** Sunday was the slaves' only day off. Most were required to show up to their masters' churches and sit in the balconies. *(looks up and back, searching for Hetty)* **(Pg 40)** The slaves began their babble and laughter in the upper galleries. Reverend Hall mounted the pulpit . . . .

TOGETHER: . . . pointed his finger and quoted scripture. *(Each assumes the character of a bombastic minister, strutting around the stage)* Slaves, be obedient to them that are your masters. Slaves, I admonish you to be content with your lot, for it is the will of God! Your obedience is mandated by scripture. Take heed and may God in his mercy grant that you will be humbled this day and return to your masters as faithful *(their pacing brings them face to fac on the last word, which is spoken more quietly in the girls own voices)* servants.

SARAH: **(Pg 41)** If everyone was so keen to Christianize the slaves, why weren't they taught to read the Bible for themselves? *(Shakes her head. Beat)*

MOTHER: **(Pg 38)** Sarah, I trust you're prepared to give your first lesson.

SARAH: I'd recently become a new teacher in the Colored Sunday School, a class taught by girls, thirteen years and older, but Mother had prodded Reverend Hall to make an exception. *(Turns to her class, she begins to sing the alphabet)* **(Pg 41)** A, B, C, D, E, F, G . . . *(they get louder and louder)*

TOGETHER: *(Hetty joins in)* H, I J, K, L, M, N, O, P

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REVERENDHALL: **(Pg 42)** *(angry and pious)*What is going on here! We do not sing in Colored Sunday School and we most assuredly do not sing the alphabet. Are you aware it is against the law to teach a slave to read?

SARAH: **(Pg 41)** I thought of Hetty. I knew she explored the books on my desk. How she would love to learn these twenty-six letters!

HETTY: *(whisper-singing to herself)* A, B, C, D, E, F G

SARAH: **(Pg 57)** Hetty, shall I teach you to read? *(Hetty nods vigorously and the girls turn their attention to a slate and learning) (to audience)* I'd never taught anyone to read, but as it turned out, Hetty had a knack. I'll never forget the moment when she made the magical connection and the letters passed from nonsense into meaning. **(Pg 278)** I told myself reading was a kind of freedom, the only one I could give.

HETTY: How do you spell Hetty?

SARAH: H-E-T-T-Y *(Hetty writes on her slate)*

HETTY: **(Pg 60)** My real name is Handful. **(Pg 57)** How do you spell water?

SARAH: W-A-T-E-R *(Hetty writes on her slate)* Once, I glimpsed her in the work yard writing in the dirt with a stick. *(Hetty drops to her knees to do so)* She'd scrawled WATER for the entire world to see. *(Sarah races to rub the letters away with her foot).* What are you doing? Someone will see!

HETTY: *(Proud of herself, but instantly scared, she helps erase the letters)* Don't you think I got my own foot to rub out letters! *(to audience)* Since that day [when] I found how to read and write . . . **(Pg 84)** I found the part that refused to bow and scrape, and once you find that, you got trouble breathing on your neck. *(Hetty exits)*

SARAH: **(Pg 9)** Father was a judge on South Carolina's highest court. Everyone said I was Father's favorite. **(Pg 39)** [But] Father was furious.

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FATHER: **(Pg 66-70)** You have disappointed me, Sarah. *(He holds out his palm to stop her reply)* I have brought you here to listen. Do not speak. It has been brought to my attention that your slave girl has become literate. Do not deny it. She wrote a number of words on the muddy ground in the yard and even took care to sign her name.

SARAH: *(to audience)* Oh, no! Handful had been careless. We'd been found out. But my mind could not accept that Father, of all people, believed her ability to read was an unpardonable offense. *(To father)* I'm sorry, father . . . I meant no harm.

FATHER: No harm? You taught her! From now on, you are denied all access to books.

SARAH: No books! Father, I beg you . . . P-please, don't take books from me. *(Sarah exits crying and as she reaches the porch, she sees Hetty, her arms tied to the porch rail)*

HETTY: *(her back to audience, arms crossed above her head, she takes 3 lashes from an unseen hand; both girls react to each lash)*

******* long beat ******

HETTY: **(Pg 43)** What came next was a fast, bitter wind.

OVERSEER: **(Pg 164)** Your owner has decided the Work House will put you in a wholesome frame of mind.

HETTY: **(Pg 35)** Far as I knew, not one Grimke slave had gone to the Work House. The white folks called it the Work House. Like the slaves were in there sewing clothes and hammering horseshoes. But I knew about the torture house on Magazine Street. I knew about the dark hole they put you in and left you by yourself for weeks. I knew about the **(Pg 164)** treadmill.

SARAH: **(Pg 338)** I remember watching it unfold as if from a distance.

HETTY: **(Pg 174)** *(Hetty holds a bar above her head, walks on the Mill Wheel crying)* I'm gripping the bar with all the strength I got. Climbing the wheel, climbing the wheel.

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SARAH: **(Pg 340)** I cried too, but my tears were a mix of wretchedness and fear.

HETTY: **(Pg 174)** The knot that lashes my wrist to it comes loose.

SARAH: **(Pg 351)** Slavery is a hell-concocted system.

HETTY: **(Pg 174)** A child screams. Don't look, keep going. [But] I look and its little head is bleeding. Red and wet. And I fell . . . . *(Sarah gasps and kneels over the dying body of Hetty)*

SARAH: **(Pg 166)** Handful's foot was twisted inward at an unnatural angle and there was a gash exposing raw flesh. **(Pg 351)**

HETTY: **(Pg 3)** Mauma told me there was a time in Africa the people could fly. **(Pg 174)** [But] there ain't no wings sprouting off my shoulders.

SARAH: **(Pg 351)** *(Sarah kisss Hetty's forehead, stands and speaks through angry tears)* The Negro is not some other kind of creature than we are. **(Pg 323)** Not chattel to be owned, but a person under God. **(Pg 351)** Whiteness is not sacred! *(Sarah begins to hum the chorus from "I'll Fly Away" while Hetty speaks the final lines)*

HETTY: *(Hetty speaks as her eyelids fall shut on the world)* **(Pg 324)** What was it for? What was any of this for?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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Lyrics and Music to I'll Fly Away can be found here
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ln1YjA69ZzE

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